

RELIGIOUS PLURALISM AND THE PROBLEM OF ABSOLUTE TRUTH

FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY → EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM → JOHN HICK → VEDĀNTIC MODELS → JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS → TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

Read the thick cyan rail from Stage 00 to the final core synthesis. Each card uses a concept-appropriate structure; the grey E card is optional enrichment only and never repairs missing core content.

PRIMARY CORE FLOW SUBORDINATE EXTRA APPROVAL / REVIEW

Approval: FALSE • Pending user review • source generation g11 repaired in place; prior artifacts unchanged outside the scoped current generation

CORE BEFORE EXTRA • prior artefacts unchanged • exact same master drives poster and tiles

00

STAGE 00 FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY

FOUR AXES OF DIVERSITY RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES TRUTH CONTRADICTORY DOCTRINAL CLAIMS SALVATION WHO CAN ATTAIN LIBERATION/SALVATION? EPISTEMIC STATUS ARE OTHERS REASONABLE/JUSTIFIED? CIVIC STATUS WHAT FREEDOM AND EQUALITY ARE OWED?

RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?

epistemic status: are others reasonable/justified?

civic status: what freedom and equality are owed?

PLURALISM can answer one axis without answering all tolerance is a political/moral practice

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?
- epistemic status: are others reasonable/justified?

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- civic status: what freedom and equality are owed?
- PLURALISM can answer one axis without answering all tolerance is a political/moral practice

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- it is not yet a metaphysical claim that all religions are equally true.
- RELIGIOUS DIVERSITY OCCURS ALONG FOUR AXES truth: contradictory doctrinal claims salvation: who can attain liberation/salvation?

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism must answer four distinct questions—truth, salvation, coexistence and epistemic humility—rather than treating social tolerance as proof that all doctrines are true.

01

STAGE 01 EXCLUSIVISM-INCLUSIVISM-PLURALISM

ONE TRADITION ALONE HAS SAVING TRUTH ONE NORM IS FINAL, BUT GRACE/TRUTH OPERATES BEYOND EXPLICIT MULTIPLE TRADITIONS ARE VALID RESPONSES/ROUTES TO ULTIMATE REALITY STRENGTHS EXCLUSIVISM PRESERVES DETERMINATE TRUTH; INCLUSIVISM WIDENS SALVATION

PLURALISM EXPLAINS DIVERSITY AND SUPPORTS HUMILITY COSTS PATRONISING ABSORPTION FLATTENING REAL CONTRADICTIONS EACH MODEL MUST STATE TRUTH CRITERION

EXCLUSIVISM: one tradition alone has saving truth

INCLUSIVISM: one norm is final, but grace/truth operates beyond explicit membership

PLURALISM: multiple traditions are valid responses/routes to ultimate reality strengths: exclusivism preserves determinate truth

inclusivism widens salvation

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- EXCLUSIVISM: one tradition alone has saving truth
- INCLUSIVISM: one norm is final, but grace/truth operates beyond explicit membership
- PLURALISM: multiple traditions are valid responses/routes to ultimate reality strengths: exclusivism preserves determinate truth

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- inclusivism widens salvation
- pluralism explains diversity and supports humility costs: exclusion
- patronising absorption

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- flattening real contradictions each model must state truth criterion, salvation criterion and view of disagreement.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Exclusivism reserves decisive truth, inclusivism recognises others through one fulfilment, and pluralism grants independently valid responses to ultimacy.

02

STAGE 02 JOHN HICK

JOHN HICK THE REAL AN SICH (NOUMENAL, BEYOND FULL CONCEPTUAL CAPTURE) PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS GOD, ALLAH, ĪŚVARA NON-PERSONAL REPRESENTATIONS BRAHMAN, NIRVĀṆA, EMPTINESS RELIGIONS ASSESSED BY TRANSFORMATION FROM SELF-CENTREDNESS

KANTIAN DISTINCTION EXPLAINS DIVERSITY WITHOUT DECLARING ALL PROPOSITIONS IDENTICAL HICK IMPOSES A META-THEORY; THE REAL BECOMES UNKNOWABLE; TRANSFORMATION

THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses

personal representations: God, Allah, Īśvara

non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāṇa, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness

KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses
- personal representations: God, Allah, Īśvara

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāṇa, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness
- KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- the Real becomes unknowable
- transformation test is vague.

03

self-centredness to Reality-centredness

meta-theory

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- THE REAL AN SICH (noumenal, beyond full conceptual capture) culturally shaped human responses
- personal representations: God, Allah, Īśvara

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- non-personal representations: Brahman, nirvāṇa, emptiness religions assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness
- KANTIAN distinction explains diversity without declaring all propositions identical objections: Hick imposes a meta-theory

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- the Real becomes unknowable
- transformation test is vague.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Hick explains religions as culturally mediated responses to the Real, but the unknowability of the Real threatens to make the hypothesis unverifiable and covertly privileged.

03

STAGE 03VEDĀNTIC MODELS

VEDĀNTIC MODELS

ONE BRAHMAN; DIFFERENCES BELONG TO EMPIRICAL STANDPOINT

MANY PATHS MAY PREPARE FOR NON-DUAL KNOWLEDGE

REAL PLURALITY WITHIN BRAHMAN'S UNITY; DEVOTION TO PERSONAL GOD

DIVERSE RELIGIOUS PATHS CAN REALISE ONE ULTIMATE

ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM IF ALL VIEWS ARE PARTIAL, IS "ALL

REPLY REQUIRES STANDPOINT DISCIPLINE, NOT EFFORTLESS EQUIVALENCE OF INCOMPATIBLE

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE	DECISIVE DISTINCTION	EVALUATION / TRAP
ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint	RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final	ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge	RĀMAKRṢṆA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate	reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

SYSTEM / DOCTRINE

- ADVAITA: one Brahman; differences belong to empirical standpoint
- many paths may prepare for non-dual knowledge

DECISIVE DISTINCTION

- RĀMĀNUJA: real plurality within Brahman's unity; devotion to personal God remains final
- RĀMAKRṢṆA/VIVEKĀNANDA: diverse religious paths can realise one ultimate

EVALUATION / TRAP

- ABSOLUTE-TRUTH PROBLEM if all views are partial, is "all are partial" itself absolute?
- reply requires standpoint discipline, not effortless equivalence of incompatible claims.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Vedāntic pluralism distinguishes one ultimate reality from diverse conceptual and devotional approaches, but unity must not erase genuine doctrinal contradiction.

04

STAGE 04JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

JAIN MANY-SIDEDNESS

REALITY HAS MANY ASPECTS

EACH FINITE STATEMENT ARISES FROM A STANDPOINT

PREDICATE CONDITIONALLY — IN A CERTAIN RESPECT PLURALIST USE

RIVAL RELIGIONS MAY DISCLOSE DIFFERENT ASPECTS WITHOUT EXHAUSTIVE POSSESSION

EPISTEMIC HUMILITY + NON-VIOLENCE IN JUDGEMENT LIMIT

CONTRADICTIONS ARE RECONCILED ONLY IF RESPECTS GENUINELY DIFFER

SYĀDVĀDA CANNOT SIMPLY PRONOUNCE EVERY DOCTRINE TRUE IN THE

ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use; rival religions may disclose different

possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects
- NAYAVĀDA: each finite statement arises from a standpoint

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- SYĀDVĀDA: predicate conditionally — in a certain respect pluralist use; rival religions may disclose different aspects without exhaustive
- possession strength: epistemic humility + non-violence in judgement limit: contradictions are reconciled only if respects genuinely differ

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- syādvāda cannot simply pronounce every doctrine true in the same sense.
- ANEKĀNTAVĀDA: reality has many aspects

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Anekāntavāda (doctrine of many-sided reality) and nayavāda (doctrine of partial standpoints) justify humility about perspectives without implying that contradictory propositions are simultaneously true in the same respect.

05

STAGE 05TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

TOLERANCE AND RELIGIOUS FREEDOM

REFRAIN FROM COERCION DESPITE DISAGREEMENT RESPECT

RECOGNISE EQUAL STANDING

RECIPROCAL REASON-GIVING FREEDOM

BELIEF, PRACTICE, CHANGE OF RELIGION, NON-BELIEF, ASSOCIATION

LIMITS COERCION

HARM TO RIGHTS MAY BE REGULATED BUT OFFENCE OR

TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

LIMITS coercion

harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing
- dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- LIMITS coercion
- harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient ground for suppression

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism.
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Religious freedom protects belief, practice, change and non-belief, but public restriction is justified only by neutral, proportionate protection of rights and order.

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dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

LIMITS coercion

harm to rights may be regulated but offence or theological falsity alone is not sufficient

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing
- dialogue: reciprocal reason-giving freedom: belief, practice, change of religion, non-belief, association

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- LIMITS coercion
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IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- principled pluralism protects persons and conscience, not every practice from criticism.
- TOLERANCE: refrain from coercion despite disagreement respect: recognise equal standing

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06

STAGE 06

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT, UNIFICATION AND DEEP DISAGREEMENT

CONFLICT SOURCES

EXCLUSIVE REVELATION

SACRED HISTORY

GRIEVANCE RESPONSES

COMMON ETHICAL CORE

COMPARATIVE THEOLOGY

LEGAL NEUTRALITY

CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation

sacred history

grievance responses: syncretism

common ethical core

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- CONFLICT SOURCES: exclusive revelation
- sacred history
- grievance responses: syncretism

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- common ethical core
- comparative theology
- legal neutrality

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap,
- preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect
- without equalising every truth claim.

MECHANISM / VERDICT — DEEP DISAGREEMENT persists because standards of evidence are tradition-shaped humility != relativism: give reasons, admit fallibility, seek overlap, preserve dissent objections to pluralism: self-refuting, imperial meta-theory, doctrinal dilution reply: modest pluralism can defend equal civic respect without equalising every truth claim.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Deep religious disagreement persists because evidence is interpreted through rival frameworks, yet rational dialogue remains possible through internal critique, shared reasons and epistemic humility.

07

STAGE 07

PYQ ANSWER SPINE

PYQ ANSWER SPINE

DEFINE AXIS

MAP EXCLUSIVISM/INCLUSIVISM/PLURALISM

EXPLAIN HICK EXACTLY

COMPARE ADVAITA/RĀMĀNUJA/JAIN ANEKĀNTA

TEST ABSOLUTE-TRUTH OBJECTION

MOVE FROM METAPHYSICAL DIVERSITY TO TOLERANCE/FREEDOM WITH LIMITS

QUALIFIED CONCLUSION

DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly

compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection

move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits

qualified conclusion

CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither “all religions say the same” nor relativism

SOURCE / DOCTRINE

- DEFINE axis → map exclusivism/inclusivism/pluralism → explain Hick exactly
- compare Advaita/Rāmānuja/Jain anekānta → test absolute-truth objection

ARGUMENT / MECHANISM

- move from metaphysical diversity to tolerance/freedom with limits
- qualified conclusion

IMPLICATION / VERDICT

- CLOSE: defensible pluralism is neither “all religions say the same” nor relativism
- it combines truth-seeking, fallibilism, transformative comparison and equal civic liberty.

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Pluralism need not deny absolute truth; it denies exhaustive possession of truth by any finite perspective and therefore supports a bounded, non-relativist openness.

E

EXTRA

SUBORDINATE ENRICHMENT — ONLY AFTER THE COMPLETE CORE

OPTIONAL ADVANCED ENRICHMENT

ADVANCED-DOSSIER RECONCILIATION — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]

DOCTRINE STATEMENT.

EXCLUSIVISM MAKES ONE TRADITION'S DECISIVE TRUTH/SALVATION CLAIM UNIQUELY VALID

INCLUSIVISM GRANTS TRUTH OR SALVATION BEYOND IT WHILE INTERPRETING

EXCLUSIVISM APPEALS TO DETERMINATE REVELATION AND NON-CONTRADICTION.

INCLUSIVISM ADDS UNIVERSALITY OF DIVINE GRACE WHILE PRESERVING NORMATIVE

PRESUPPOSITION. CAUTION

OPTIONAL SOURCE WITNESS

- Advanced-dossier reconciliation — [OPTIONAL ADVANCED]
- Doctrine statement.
- Exclusivism makes one tradition's decisive truth/salvation claim uniquely valid
- inclusivism grants truth or salvation beyond it while interpreting that success through the home tradition.

ADVANCED OBJECTION

- Argument.
- Exclusivism appeals to determinate revelation and non-contradiction.
- Inclusivism adds universality of divine grace while preserving normative priority.
- Presupposition. CAUTION: One revelation has privileged warrant, and salvation can be specified independently enough to compare traditions.

COMPARATIVE NUANCE

- Distinction. Inclusivism is not pluralism: others are included on terms set by the privileged tradition.
- Canonical example. Rahner's "anonymous Christian" is a standard inclusivist model.
- Objection → reply.
- CAUTION: Inclusivism appears patronising.

OPTIONAL STATUS — This optional depth is unnecessary for a competent core answer; use it only for added nuance after the complete core has been written.